

CLUE & CANDLE GAMES PRESENTS

HOST GUIDE · NO SPOILERS INSIDE

The **Thistledown** *Supper*

A Cozy Dinner Party Murder Mystery

4-8 PLAYERS

2-2.5 HOURS

PRINTABLE PDF

Everything you need to host, from one week before to the final toast.
The answer is not in this file, so you can play and guess too.



CLUE & CANDLE GAMES

US LETTER + A4

Welcome, Host

READ THIS FIRST

Thank you for hosting! This guide takes you through everything, even if you have never run a murder mystery before. You don't need to act, memorize anything or know the answer. You simply serve three courses, read four short scripts and hand out the evidence.



The story in one minute

Autumn, the 1930s. Bartholomew “Barty” Thistle, retired jam magnate, has invited a few old friends to the Harvest Supper at Thistledown House. Before the soup was served, Barty took a glass of elderflower cordial in the study, sat down for a rest, and never woke up. Someone at this table knows why. The river has flooded the lane, so the Inspector cannot reach Thistledown until morning and has asked everyone to stay, eat supper and keep their eyes open. Every guest had a reason to be cross with Barty. One of them did something about it.



How the evening works

COURSE	WHAT HAPPENS
Starter (Round 1)	You read Script 2 and lay out Evidence #1–#3. Players open Round 1 in their booklets: things to share, two questions for named characters and a small task.
Main Course (Round 2)	Script 3, Evidence #4–#6, Round 2. Secrets start to come out.
Dessert (Round 3)	Script 4, Evidence #7–#9, Round 3. The last pieces fall into place.
After dessert	Everyone fills in an accusation ballot. Then a player opens file 99 and reads the solution aloud.

GOLDEN RULES (READ THESE OUT AT THE START)

- Open each round in your booklet only when the host calls it.
- You may bend the truth about your own secrets, but never about the evidence.
- Anyone may ask anyone anything. Evidence stays on the table for all to see.
- Nobody opens file 99 until every ballot is in.

Preparation Checklist

TICK AS YOU GO



One week before

- ☐ Pick a date and choose the full evening (about 2 hours 20 minutes) or the quick version (75 minutes).
- ☐ Count your guests (4 to 8) and find your row in the casting table on the next page.
- ☐ Send invitations from file 02, or copy the text version into an email or message.
- ☐ Assign characters. The host takes booklet 10 or 11; give out the others freely.
- ☐ Plan your three courses (menu ideas on page 11). Simple shop-bought food is perfectly fine.



Two or three days before

- ☐ Give each player **only their own booklet**, printed single-sided or sent as a PDF, and ask them to read pages 1 and 2 only.
- ☐ Print the rest using the print list in file 00.
- ☐ Cut out the evidence cards, name tags, place cards and ballots.
- ☐ Put the evidence cards into three envelopes: Starter (E1–E3), Main (E4–E6), Dessert (E7–E9).
- ☐ Seal file 99, printed unread, in an envelope marked “Open after the vote.”



On the day

- ☐ Set the table with place cards, the menu card and the “Evidence” table sign.
- ☐ Lay out name tags, pens and one Detective Notes sheet per player.
- ☐ Keep this guide, the three evidence envelopes and the ballots by your seat.
- ☐ Put on some 1930s music, light a candle or two, and enjoy yourself.

PLAYERS	BOOKLETS	WHO PLAYS
4	10, 11, 12, 13	Rowan Thistle, Ellis Fairweather, Morgan Pike, Sage Whitlock
5	10–14	the four above + Harper Vale
6	10–15	+ Harper Vale, Quinn Ashby
7	10–16	+ Harper Vale, Quinn Ashby, Avery Lark
8	10–17	all eight characters

THE HOST'S BOOKLET

You, the host, take booklet 10 (Rowan Thistle) or booklet 11 (Ellis Fairweather). Hand out every other booklet freely.

- Booklets 10–13 are the **core** characters. All four are always played, so give them to guests who have confirmed they're coming.
- Add optional characters in number order: Harper (14) at 5 players, Quinn (15) at 6, Avery (16) at 7, Jules (17) at 8.
- Every role works for any gender. Booklets use names, not gendered pronouns.
- Nobody needs acting experience. Reading the prompts aloud is plenty.



Fewer players? Nothing breaks

The clue trail runs entirely through the four core booklets and the nine evidence cards. Optional characters add suspects, alibis and red herrings. If a character isn't cast, they simply weren't at Thistledown tonight. Skip any question in a booklet that names someone who isn't playing.

OPTIONAL CHARACTER	JOINS AT	WHAT THEY ADD
14 Harper Vale, food critic	5 players	A lawsuit over a jam review, and a view of the main stairs
15 Quinn Ashby, head gardener	6 players	The cordial's maker, and Barty's last hour in the garden
16 Avery Lark, reporter	7 players	A late arrival and an anonymous tip-off
17 Jules Marchetti, visiting chef	8 players	A kitchen quarrel, and sounds from across the hall

IF A CORE PLAYER CANCELS

The game needs all four core characters. Give the missing core booklet to whoever was going to play an optional character, and leave that optional role out.

Timelines

FULL EVENING OR QUICK VERSION



Full evening · 140 minutes (2 hours 20 minutes)

SEGMENT	WHAT YOU DO	MINUTES
Arrival, drinks and name tags	Guests arrive in costume; hand out name tags and Detective Notes.	15
Script 1 · Welcome and introductions	Read Script 1; each guest introduces their character in a minute.	15
Round 1 · Starter	Serve the starter, read Script 2, reveal E1–E3, open Round 1.	25
Round 2 · Main Course	Serve the main, read Script 3, reveal E4–E6, open Round 2.	35
Round 3 · Dessert	Serve dessert, read Script 4, reveal E7–E9, open Round 3.	25
Accusation	Quiet time with notes, then everyone fills in a ballot.	10
Reveal and awards	A player opens file 99 and reads Script 5; score ballots; awards.	15
Total		140



Quick version · 75 minutes

SEGMENT	WHAT YOU DO	MINUTES
Welcome	Read Script 1, shortened if you like.	5
Introductions	Name, role and one line each.	5
Round 1 · Starter	Script 2, E1–E3, Round 1.	15
Round 2 · Main Course	Script 3, E4–E6, Round 2.	20
Round 3 · Dessert	Script 4, E7–E9, Round 3.	15
Accusation	Ballots.	5
Reveal	Script 5 from file 99, scores.	10
Total		75

QUICK-VERSION TIPS

Ask players to read pages 1 and 2 of their booklets before they arrive. Serve the food buffet-style and set a phone timer for each round.

Script 1 • Welcome

BEFORE THE STARTER

BEFORE YOU READ

Everyone is seated with a name tag, a pen, a Detective Notes sheet and their own booklet. Read the four golden rules from page 2 first.

READ ALOUD

Good evening, and welcome to Thistledown House. It is autumn in the 1930s, the lamps are lit, and the table is laid for the Harvest Supper.

Our host, Bartholomew Thistle, known to everyone as Barty, made a fortune from jam and spent it on this rambling old house, its gardens and its suppers.

This evening, shortly before the soup, Barty took a glass of elderflower cordial in the study, sat down in the armchair for a rest, and never woke up.

Our doctor tells us it was no natural turn.

The river has flooded the lane, so the Inspector cannot reach us until morning. The Inspector has asked us all to stay, eat our supper and keep our eyes open.

Every one of us had some reason to be cross with Barty, and one of us did something about it.

So, before the soup arrives, please stand one at a time and tell the table your name, who you are, and how you knew Barty.

IF THE TABLE GOES QUIET

- Go around the table in booklet order (10, 11, 12...). Each player reads the “At the table you are” line on page 1 of their booklet, in character.
- Ask each guest: “When did you arrive at Thistledown today?”

Script 2 • The Starter

ROUND 1

BEFORE YOU READ

Serve the starter. Have the Starter envelope (Evidence #1–#3) ready.

READ ALOUD

The soup is served, and so is the first evidence.

While we were finding our seats, the house has been searched. I am placing three items on the table: Evidence 1, 2 and 3.

Would three volunteers please read one card each, aloud, slowly, so we all hear every word.

Now open your booklet to Round 1 on page 3, and only Round 1. Keep Round 2 folded away.

Share what your booklet asks you to share, put your two questions to the people named, and try your small task before the bowls are cleared.

Remember: you may bend the truth about your own secrets, but never about the evidence.

In about twenty-five minutes the main course will arrive, and so will more evidence.

IF THE TABLE GOES QUIET

- Ask: “Who saw Barty last, and at what time?”
- Ask: “What can the times on these cards tell us?”
- Invite the quietest player to ask the first question.

Script 3 • The Main Course

ROUND 2

BEFORE YOU READ

Clear the starter and serve the main course. Have the Main envelope (Evidence #4–#6) ready.

READ ALOUD

The main course is served: Barty's favorite Sunday roast, as Barty would have wished.

While we ate our soup, the study was searched again, and three more items have turned up: Evidence 4, 5 and 6.

Would three different volunteers please read them aloud.

Please open Round 2 in your booklet now. Some of you will find that it is time to confess a secret or two.

Share what you are asked to share, ask your two questions and try your task.

Use your Detective Notes: where was everyone between a quarter to six and half past six?

Dessert will follow, with the last of the evidence.

IF THE TABLE GOES QUIET

- Ask: "Has anyone's story changed since the starter?"
- Ask: "Which two cards on the table seem to talk to each other?"
- Ask each player to name one person they now trust, and why.

Script 4 • Dessert

ROUND 3

BEFORE YOU READ

Serve dessert. Have the Dessert envelope (Evidence #7–#9) and the ballots ready.

READ ALOUD

Dessert is served, and with it the last of the evidence: Evidence 7, 8 and 9.

Would three volunteers please read them aloud.

Open Round 3 on page 4 of your booklet. This is your final chance to share, to ask and to press for answers.

Lay out every card from all three rounds where everyone can see it, and compare your notes.

When the plates are cleared, each of us will name who did it, how, and why.

Choose carefully. The Inspector arrives at first light, and so will the truth.

IF THE TABLE GOES QUIET

- Ask: “Who had the most to lose if Barty lived until Monday?”
- Ask: “Whose story doesn’t match the cards?”
- Ask each player to point to the single card that convinced them most.

Accusation & Reveal

AFTER DESSERT



The accusation (about 10 minutes)

1. Hand every player, including yourself, one ballot from file 32.
2. Give everyone five quiet minutes with their notes and the nine evidence cards.
3. Each player writes **who** did it, **how**, **why**, and up to three key evidence numbers.
4. Fold the ballots and collect them in a bowl. No changes after this point!



How to reveal

1. Hand the sealed file 99 to any player. Draw a name from the bowl, or ask for a volunteer.
2. That player opens it, turns past the STOP page, and reads **Script 5** aloud to the table. Everyone, the host included, hears the answer at the same moment.
3. Read out each ballot and score it with the scoring page at the end of file 99.
4. Present the awards from file 34: **Best Detective** (highest score) and **Best Performance** (by a show of hands).

MAKE IT A MOMENT

Dim the lights, light a candle beside the reader, and let the reader take their time. Toast the winners, then toast Barty.

Hosting Tips & Menu

 Hosting tips

- **Keep time gently.** Each course is a round. When plates are cleared, the round is over.
- **Bring in quiet players** by asking them to read an evidence card or to put their first question.
- **Accents and costumes are optional.** A scarf, a hat or a prop is plenty.
- **Late arrivals** read page 2 of their booklet and catch up from the evidence on the table.
- **Stuck?** Use the “If the table goes quiet” questions under each script.
- **Photos:** the place cards and table sign make a nice backdrop for a group picture before the reveal.

 Menu ideas: one dish per round

COURSE	DISH	IN A SENTENCE
Starter	Thistledown Harvest Soup	Roasted squash and apple soup with a swirl of cream and toasted seeds.
Main Course	Barty’s Sunday Roast Chicken	Golden roast chicken with herbed potatoes and honeyed carrots (or a mushroom and chestnut pie).
Dessert	Elderflower & Blackberry Crumble	Warm fruit crumble with custard, a nod to Barty’s favorite cordial.

To drink: elderflower cordial or sparkling elderflower for everyone (it’s Barty’s favorite, after all), with sherry or wine for adults if you like. Shop-bought soup, a roast from the deli and a bakery crumble work beautifully. The file 34 menu card has blank lines so you can write in your own dishes.

Printing & Folding



Printing

- Use the print list in file 00 for your player count. Print at 100% (“Actual size”).
- **Booklets: print single-sided**, so that later rounds can’t show through. Or send each player their own booklet as a PDF.
- Black-and-white printing works well for everything.
- Print file 99 last, without reading it, and seal it in an envelope.



Folding and cutting

- **Booklet page 3:** fold along the dashed line so Round 2 is hidden behind Round 1 until the main course. Players may also cut along it.
- **Evidence cards (file 30):** cut on the dashed lines. Cutting won’t spoil the ending, because every guest sees all nine cards during the game. If you’d rather be surprised, ask a helper to cut and envelope them.
- **Card backs** (page 3 of file 30) are optional; print them on the back of the evidence pages or skip them.
- **Name tags and place cards (file 31):** cut out; fold each place card along the dotted line so it stands up.
- **Ballots (file 32):** 4 per page; print a second copy for 5–8 players.
- **Menu and table cards (file 34):** fold the table signs along the dotted line.

ENVELOPES

Label three envelopes Starter, Main and Dessert for the evidence, and a fourth “File 99 · Open after the vote.” That’s all the props you need.